CURTIN EXECUTIVE EDUCATION · FIELD GUIDE

AI for professionals

Building everyday capability

Four tools for using AI with judgement. Everyone has the same tools now. What you add is knowing what to ask, when to trust the answer, and where a person stays in charge.

01 TRUST TOOL

02 RTCF

03 CHECK LOOP

04 OPPORTUNITY FINDER

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THE GUIDE ON ONE PAGE

Same tools. Different judgement.

Generative AI predicts the most plausible answer. What comes back is a convincing average: fluent, well-shaped and usually about right. Most of the time that is useful. Sometimes you need the exact answer, and the average is a guess that looks like one.

The hard part is that AI's mistakes don't look like mistakes. A rushed human draft shows its gaps. AI's wrong work arrives polished and confident, so the instinct you rely on to spot weak work stays quiet. The four tools in this guide replace that instinct with a short, repeatable check. They work on any AI product, and they don't expire when the next model ships.

EXHIBIT 1 · FOUR TOOLS, ONE PER QUESTION

01 · TRUST TOOL

How much should I trust this output?

Two questions place any output in one of four corners. The corner sets the check.

02 · RTCF

How do I ask for what I need?

Role, Task, Context, Format. Plus four upgrades when the output is still weak.

03 · CHECK LOOP

How do I know it's right?

Frame, explore, verify, shape. Verification comes from outside the tool.

04 · OPPORTUNITY FINDER

Where does it fit in my week?

Spot the signals, decide who leads each step, then start with quick wins.

Each tool answers one question. Use them in any order; the trust tool runs underneath all of them.

How the tools fit together

WHEN YOU···	USE	THE MOVE
Look for where AI could help	Opportunity Finder	Spot a recurring task, decide who leads each step, start with a quick win.
Are about to type a prompt	RTCF	Brief it like a capable new colleague. Context does most of the work.
Get an output back	Trust tool	How exact must it be? What if it's wrong? The corner tells you how hard to check.
Work with data or facts	Check loop	Frame the question, explore, verify from outside, then say what you checked.

> **Three principles run through all four.** Brief it, don't spell it: there are no magic words, only good briefs. Verify from outside: the tool can't reliably check its own work. Your name goes on the output, not the tool's.

TOOL 1

01 The trust tool

How much should I trust this output?

Ask two questions about any output before you act on it. The answers place it in one of four corners, and the corner tells you how much checking it needs.

Question 1 · How exact must it be?

Average: the ballpark is fine. A draft, a summary, ideas to react to.
Precise: there is one right answer and close is the same as wrong. A figure, a name, a date, a citation, a clause.

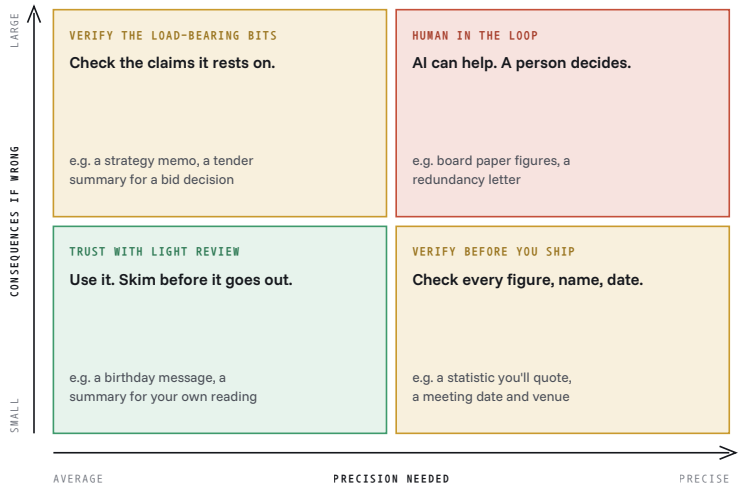
Question 2 · What happens if it's wrong?

Small: cheap to fix, easy to reverse, nobody harmed.
Large: money, safety, reputation, someone's job or wellbeing.

Rule of thumb

Lean in where about-right on low stakes is fine. Keep a person in charge where exactly-right meets high stakes. Most AI failures in the news are top-right outputs treated as bottom-left ones.

EXHIBIT 2 · THE TRUST TOOL



Same layout and corner names as the practice game at trusttool.borck.education.

Check from outside the tool. Asking the AI "are you sure?" doesn't count: it tends to agree with itself. The check comes from the data, the source document, a colleague who knows, or your own arithmetic. That is an old professional skill, not a new AI one.

Better models move the corners. They need less checking on easy ground. They never remove the obligation to place the output first. Capability raises the floor; it doesn't remove the review.

Practise until it's a reflex

The free game at **trusttool.borck.education** has ten scenarios per domain with an explanation on every card. Then place three tasks from your own week. Where you hesitate is usually a question about stakes: who sees this next, and what do they do with it?

TOOL 2

02 RTCF

How do I ask for what I need?

Prompting is briefing, not spell-casting. Write the prompt the way you would brief a smart, fast colleague who is new to your job. Everything they would need to know belongs in the brief.

EXHIBIT 3 · THE FOUR PARTS OF A BRIEF

PART	ASK YOURSELF	EXAMPLE	NOTE
Role	Who should it write as?	A senior HR adviser in a mid-sized Australian firm	Sets tone and vocabulary. The lightest of the four.
Task	What exactly, and how much?	Draft a reply to the client. Under 200 words.	Use a clear verb and a scope: how many, how long.
Context	What does it need to know?	18-month client. Their board shifted priorities. I want a meeting, not a rewrite.	**Does most of the work.** The only part the tool can't guess.
Format	What should it look like?	Email. Acknowledge, explain, propose, close.	Ask for the shape you'll paste, so you don't have to rework it.

Not every prompt needs all four. Anything that matters does.

Before

```
Write an email about the project delay.
```

Generic, polite, and unusable without a rewrite.

After

```
ROLE     Senior project manager. Plain-spoken and warm.
TASK     Write to the client about a two-week delivery delay.
CONTEXT  A vendor's API integration ran late. The client values
         transparency and the relationship is good. New date: 15
March.
FORMAT   Under 200 words. Acknowledge, explain, new date, recommit.
```

What goes in Context

Audience (who reads it and what they care about) · **situation** (what happened, what's at stake) · **constraints** (length, Australian English, policy) · **prior work** (paste the notes, the data, the earlier email) · **stakes**: "write this for someone who must decide this week and can't undo it" sharpens everything after it.

When the output is still weak: four upgrades

Add one upgrade before you rewrite from scratch. They help smaller, older and free-tier models the most, which matters if your workplace has approved a cheaper model. The best models still do better with them.

UPGRADE	WHAT IT DOES	LINE TO ADD
+ Example	Shows instead of describing. The strongest single upgrade.	`Match the length and tone of this example: [paste]`
+ Done	Defines success, and gives permission to be unsure.	`Done means under 200 words, figures only from my notes, and anything you're unsure of marked [CHECK].`
+ Questions	Surfaces the context you forgot to give.	`Before you start, ask me up to five questions.`
+ Steps	Stops the model losing the thread on long jobs.	`Give me an outline only. We'll draft one section at a time.`

> **Agreeable is not honest.** Models are tuned to please. Push back without evidence and many will fold. Add the guardrail line: `"Only change your assessment if I give you a new fact. Name the fact that changed it."`

> **Long chats drift.** After many exchanges a model absorbs your framing and stops challenging it. For anything that needs an independent read, start a fresh chat.

Five common mistakes

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS	FIX
Too vague	"Help me with this report." Nothing to work with.	Add a verb and a scope: summarise into five points for the board.
No context	Generic output you'll rewrite anyway.	Audience, situation, constraints, and the material itself.
No format	A wall of text you can't paste.	Name the shape: table, email, headings, word limit.
Too much at once	A full business case, shallow everywhere.	One section per prompt (the Steps upgrade).
Accepting the first draft	Settling for close enough.	Treat it as a draft: "shorter", "more on X", "less formal".

Save what works

A prompt you'll reuse is an asset. Save it with four things: a **name**, **when to use it**, the **prompt** with [blanks] for what changes, and the **check** it needs (its trust-tool corner). A saved prompt with its check attached is the first draft of what agent tools call a skill.

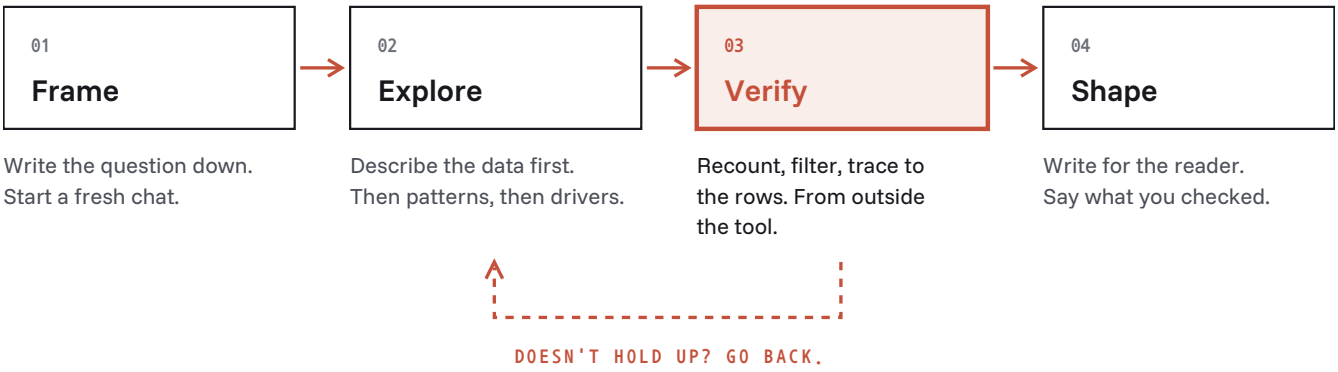
TOOL 3

03 The check loop

How do I know it's right?

AI makes analysis fast. It doesn't make it trustworthy. The check loop has four steps, and most of the value is in the third.

EXHIBIT 4 · THE CHECK LOOP



01 Frame

Write the question and the decision it feeds before you open the tool. Start a fresh chat so earlier conversation doesn't steer the analysis.

02 Explore

Ask it to describe the data first: rows, columns, dates. Does that match what you know? Then go broad to deep.

03 Verify

If a number would change a decision, check it yourself: filter, recount, open the source. If it doesn't hold, go back.

04 Shape

Write for the reader. End with one line on what you checked and how.

Can't share the data? Describe its shape instead: "500 rows; columns are date, product, region, sales, returns."

Five ways a smooth answer goes wrong

FAILURE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Miscounts	Totals that are wrong after filtering or grouping.
Correlation sold as cause	"Sunday tickets are slower, so Sundays cause complaints."
Silent gaps	Missing or messy rows skipped without saying so.
Numbers that can't all be true	Shares that add to 112%. An average above the maximum.
Invented detail	A data point, quote or source that isn't in the file.

The convincing fake. The most dangerous output isn't nonsense. It's a claim with a plausible reason and a professional tone that is simply wrong.

Fluency is not evidence. The smoother the output, the more carefully you should check what it rests on.

TOOL 4

04 The Opportunity Finder

Where does AI fit in my week?

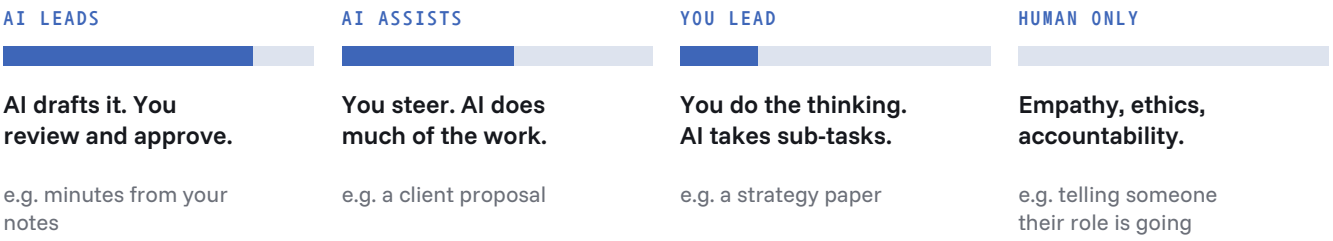
Three steps: spot the signals in your recurring work, decide who leads each step, then start with the quick wins.

1 · Spot: four signals

SIGNAL	YOU NOTICE THAT···	TYPICAL TASKS
Automate	You do it often, the same way.	Status reports, sorting requests, reformatting, data entry from forms.
Assist	You read, gather and compare.	Vendor proposals, meeting prep, long documents, staying current.
Generate	You write from a blank page.	Client emails, job ads, process documents, first drafts.
Analyse	You hunt for meaning in numbers.	Monthly KPIs, survey comments, budget variance, feedback themes.

2 · Assign: who leads each step

EXHIBIT 5 · THE TASK SPECTRUM



The bar shows roughly how much of the work AI does. When in doubt, start with more human involvement and hand over as the AI proves itself.

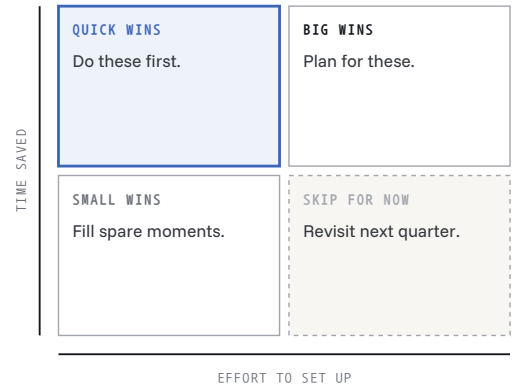
3 · Prioritise: quick wins first

For each candidate, estimate the time it would save each week and the effort to set up. Count the checking as part of the effort. A task that saves 30 minutes but needs 25 minutes of verification is not a quick win, which is why quick wins usually sit in the trust tool's green corner.

Big wins need a redesigned workflow: map the steps with honest minutes, assign who leads each one, attach the check, and test one AI step before changing the rest.

The ten-minute weekly audit. List everything you did last week that took more than 15 minutes. Mark the signal, the time and who should lead. Circle the three with the biggest saving and the cheapest check. Start with one.

EXHIBIT 6 · PRIORITY MATRIX



Worked example: the weekly team update

STEP	BEFORE	SIGNAL	WHO LEADS	TRUST CORNER · CHECK	AFTER
Gather updates from the team	15 min	-	You lead	-	15 min
Consolidate into the template	15 min	Automate	AI leads	LIGHT REVIEW	3 min
Write the summary paragraph	10 min	Generate	AI leads	LIGHT REVIEW	4 min
Calculate the project metrics	15 min	Analyse	You lead	BEFORE YOU SHIP	15 min
Send to the sponsor	5 min	-	Human only	-	5 min
Total	**60 min**				**42 min**

The saving is modest and credible. The human steps stay where judgement and accountability sit, the AI steps are green-corner work that is cheap to check, and the metrics stay with a person because a wrong figure goes straight to the sponsor. Nobody saves 90% in week one; the gain comes from running the same redesign every week.

> **Before you hand a step over, test it once with your saved prompt.** If the output needs more than a light review, the step isn't ready to trade yet. Revisit it next quarter: the line moves.

SAFEGUARDS

Three rules before you paste.

1 · Use what your organisation allows

Work accounts and approved tools first. Enterprise plans usually exclude your data from training; consumer plans often include it by default unless you opt out. Settings change, so check the data controls of whatever you use.

2 · Leave out what identifies people

Names, health details, client data, anything under NDA. If you can't share it, describe its shape instead of pasting it.

3 · Your name is on it

Never send AI output you haven't read. You own the output and the decisions made with it.

What your assistant remembers

Assistants increasingly learn across sessions. That knowledge sits in three separate stores, and they are managed separately.

STORE	WHAT IT IS	HOW TO MANAGE IT
What you told it	Facts you asked it to keep ("remember that I prefer…").	Review and delete in the memory or personalisation settings.
What it inferred	Patterns drawn from your chats. Why an assistant can start to feel too personal.	A separate setting. **Deleting chats does not delete this.**
The chats	The conversation history you can see.	Delete one at a time or in bulk in privacy or data settings.

Use a temporary or private chat for anything you don't want learned. It neither reads from nor writes to memory. At work, IT controls the enterprise settings: check what's approved before assuming where your data goes.

Agents, harnesses and skills

Agent

A model in a loop with tools. It plans, acts, checks and tries again until the job is done. AI is moving from a tool you visit to a capability inside the software you already use.

Harness

The software around the model: its standing instructions, what it can read, the tools it may call, and the model it runs on. A chat window is a harness. So is Copilot in Outlook.

Skill

A plain-text brief the harness loads when your request matches it. Your saved RTCF prompt, its format and its check are exactly what goes in one. Because it's text, it moves between tools.

An agent automates the loop, not the standard. A loop that checks its own work shares the model's blind spots. Whatever an agent produces still needs a check from outside: your test, your data, your reviewer.

KEEP PRACTISING

Work stopped training you for free.

For a century, routine work was the tuition. Digging through documents taught you what matters; building first drafts taught you what good looks like; checking numbers taught you where errors hide. AI takes that work first, so the practice that came free with the job is now something you choose.

THE EVIDENCE

Employment of 22 to 25 year olds in AI-exposed jobs is about **19% below** the trend of their peers in less-exposed jobs. There is no comparable gap for experienced workers, the change runs mostly through fewer hires rather than layoffs, and there is no sign of economy-wide job loss.

Brynjolfsson, Chandar & Chen, "Canaries in the Coal Mine?", Stanford Digital Economy Lab, revised August 2026. US payroll data to June 2026.

The compare habit

Pick one task that matters. Do a rough pass yourself first, then ask AI for its version, and compare them side by side. Where it beat you shows your weak spot. Where you beat it shows its limit, and tells you where its output needs your check. Half an hour, once a week.

Your loop

MOVE	THE QUESTION	IN YOUR ACTION PLAN
Decide	What must human eyes still judge in my work?	This quarter: name it.
Practise	Am I running the compare habit on exactly those tasks?	This week: one compare habit on a task that matters.
Trade	What has AI proven it can do reliably?	This month: hand those steps over in a redesigned workflow.
Revisit	Has the line moved since I last looked?	Every few months. The tools improve; your boundary should move too.

If you lead people

Say the reasoning out loud

When you fix someone's work, explain why the standard is the standard. Juniors used to absorb that through repetition.

Run side-by-side drills

By hand first, then with AI, then compare. A practice match, not the real game.

Choose what stays human

Decide which fundamentals your team keeps practising on purpose. Revisit as the tools improve.

Leading AI adoption and delivery is the focus of **AI in leadership and project management**. Choosing which AI projects to fund is the focus of **AI to drive business innovation**. Both are part of Curtin Executive Education's AI capability series.

Start small. Check from outside. Repeat.

Course site, data, prompt builder and this guide: michael-borck.github.io/ai-in-practice · michael.borck@curtin.edu.au